

PTI



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for those involved in paper leaks. "Those who try to harm the future of our youth will not be spared," he added.

However, fast-tracking punishment after the fact is no longer enough. What this moment demands is a system redesign that makes a leak structurally near-impossible, rather than a crime to be punished after the event. That starts with the NTA itself. The government should publish a time-bound roadmap for implementing the Radhakrishnan committee's recommendations rather than leaving them to gather dust. Secure computer-based testing, encrypted question papers, biometric checks, CCTV monitoring at every centre and independent forensic audits must become the default, not the exception.

FAST-TRACKING PUNISHMENT AFTER THE FACT IS NO LONGER ENOUGH. WHAT THIS MOMENT DEMANDS IS A SYSTEM REDESIGN

Fixing the exam only fixes the trigger, not the underlying scarcity. The second priority is capacity: millions of students compete for too few affordable seats, and private medical education remains out of reach for most families. The Centre and states must expand public colleges, medical institutions in particular, and enforce transparent, capped fee regulation rather than leaving pricing to the market. Public education spending must move steadily towards the long-promised target of 6 per cent of GDP, with funds explicitly tied to filling faculty vacancies, upgrading laboratories, hostels, libraries and digital infrastructure and strengthening research. They should also provide predictable, formula-based financing for the state universities where the majority of India's students actually study, rather than the marquee central institutions that account for only infinitesimally small numbers.

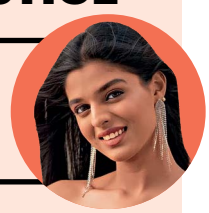
Finally, and most fundamentally, education must lead somewhere—to learning, mobility and jobs, not merely to a certificate. Curricula need updating, with industry participation built in from the start, and internships, apprenticeships, career services and functioning industry relations cells becoming baseline requirements for accreditation. Universities also need grievance systems, ombudspersons, counselling and mental-health support that actually work, given how much of this year's anger has been driven by youngsters who felt no institution gave them an ear until they took to the streets.

The government must also release the education and employment data it has been sitting on, systematically track examination-related distress rather than treating each suicide as an isolated tragedy, and publish annual reports on student outcomes, faculty strength, employability and campus safety, so that progress—or its absence—is visible year on year. The regulatory reform promised under the NEP should finally be completed, but the autonomy it grants institutions has to come bundled with accountability, not instead of it. Stripped of its jargon, the roadmap is fairly simple: no leaks, affordable seats, better-resourced teachers, degrees or diplomas that mean something, and a reasonable shot at a job at the end of it.

There are signs the government understands the politics of moving quickly, even if the substance is still catching up. This Parliament session, Modi could announce a detailed, dated implementation roadmap rather than another round of promises. A dashboard of leaks and a roadmap of reforms are necessary, but they are not the same as being heard, and this generation has made it clear it can tell the difference. Restoring public confidence will depend less on any single policy announcement than on whether the reforms it promises this session are being tracked, and delivered, long after the crowds have left Jantar Mantar. ■

VOX POP

"NO POLITICS, JUST JUSTICE"



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This is not a movement against the government or in support of any political party. The government runs on taxpayers' money, so it must be accountable. So many NEET aspirants have died by suicide. We want justice for them.